100 Essential Words & Phrases for Band 7-9 Success

A comprehensive guide to sophisticated vocabulary and natural expressions for IELTS Speaking success • IELTS Advantage

How to Use This Guide: Extracted from detailed analysis of over 50 mock IELTS Speaking tests featuring Band 7-9 responses. Demonstrates lexical range, grammatical complexity, and natural fluency. *Important:* Don't memorize these phrases or force them into every answer. Use them naturally when they fit your intended meaning. Source material access: youtube.com/watch?v=k4715CJ0li8&list=PLWWR9t3vo3OtrmF3BV0CUDTBs83i4iAo

COMPLETE LIST OF 100 ESSENTIAL PHRASES

1. Sophisticated Opinion Expressions

- **Personal Perspectives:** From my perspective..., I'm inclined to believe..., It strikes me that..., What I find particularly interesting is...
- **Balanced Views:** I have mixed feelings about..., I'm of the opinion that..., To be perfectly honest..., If I had to choose...
- **Strong Positions:** I'd argue that..., In my experience...

2. Natural Thinking Time & Hesitation

- **Opening Responses:** That's an interesting question..., Let me think about that..., Off the top of my head..., Now that you mention it..., Come to think of it...
- **Thoughtful Pauses:** Well, let me see..., How should I put this..., That's a tough one..., I haven't really thought about it before, but..., If I'm being completely honest...

3. Advanced Linking & Cohesion

- **Adding Information:** Furthermore, Moreover, In addition to that, What's more
- **Contrasting Ideas:** Nevertheless, On the contrary, Having said that, That being said, On the flip side
- **Showing Results:** Consequently

4. Expressing Degrees & Nuance

- **Partial Agreement:** To some extent, To a certain degree, More or less
- **General Statements:** By and large, For the most part, Relatively speaking
- **Degree Modifiers:** Comparatively, Substantially, Considerably, Marginally

5. Sophisticated Descriptive Language

- **Innovation & Quality:** Compelling, Innovative, Exceptional, Remarkable
- **Time & Trends:** Contemporary, Conventional, Prevalent
- **Character & Style:** Authentic, Distinctive, Sustainable

6. Explaining & Clarifying

- **Rephrasing:** What I mean by that is..., To put it another way..., In other words...
- **Focusing:** The point I'm trying to make is..., What I'm getting at is..., The way I see it...
- **Elaborating:** Let me elaborate on that..., To clarify..., More specifically..., That is to say...

7. Comparing & Contrasting

- **Showing Similarities:** In comparison with..., Similarly, Likewise
- **Showing Differences:** As opposed to..., Unlike..., In contrast, Whereas, On the other hand, Alternatively, Rather than

8. Topic-Specific Vocabulary

- **Work & Career:** Work-life balance, Career prospects
- **Society & Culture:** Cultural diversity, Social media influence
- **Environment & Tech:** Environmental impact, Technological advancement
- **Services:** Educational opportunities, Economic development, Public transportation, Healthcare system

9. Giving Examples & Evidence

- **Introducing Examples:** For instance, Take... for example, A case in point would be..., To illustrate this...
- **Demonstrating Patterns:** This is particularly true when..., This manifests itself in...
- **Showing Evidence:** This is evident in..., A perfect example of this is..., You can see this in..., Evidence of this can be found...

10. Concluding & Summarizing

- **Weighing Options:** All things considered..., Taking everything into account..., On balance...
- **Final Thoughts:** The bottom line is..., Ultimately, In conclusion, To sum up...
- **Overall Assessment:** Overall, At the end of the day..., When all is said and done...

DETAILED ANALYSIS: 16 PHRASES FOUND IN ACTUAL BAND 8-9 RESPONSES

These phrases appear exactly in real IELTS Speaking test transcripts from high-scoring candidates.

1. "To be honest..."

Purpose: Introducing a frank opinion or admitting something

> *Real IELTS Example: "To be honest, I don't think that I have a healthy diet. I usually eat whatever is available." (youtube.com/watch?v=4nrG6SHM-rY)*

How to use: "To be honest, I'm not really a morning person..." / "...social media has more negative effects..."

Why it works: Shows authenticity and willingness to admit personal weaknesses.

2. "For instance..." / "For example..."

Purpose: Providing specific examples to support your point

> *Real IELTS Example: "For example, if you're going to the office you probably want something bigger..." (youtube.com/watch?v=nJJyilEPwpk)*

How to use: "I love trying different cuisines. For instance, last week I tried Ethiopian food..."

Why it works: Demonstrates ability to support general statements with specific examples.

3. "On the other hand..."

Purpose: Presenting a contrasting viewpoint

> *Real IELTS Example: "Some people think that there shouldn't be any regulations... Other people think..." (youtube.com/watch?v=S8Y5D3RMBes)*

How to use: "Many people prefer city life. On the other hand, I find countryside living much more peaceful."

Why it works: Shows ability to consider multiple perspectives and present balanced arguments.

4. "In other words..."

Purpose: Rephrasing or clarifying what you just said

> *Real IELTS Example: "So, different clothes with different occasions... In other words, I adapt my style..." (youtube.com/watch?v=ZDv9njERj0s)*

How to use: "I'm quite introverted. In other words, I prefer spending time alone..."

Why it works: Demonstrates lexical flexibility and rephrasing ability.

5. "Similarly..."

Purpose: Comparing similar situations or drawing parallels

> *Real IELTS Example: "So we had a good relationship... Similarly, when I teach others, I try to understand..." (youtube.com/watch?v=UuNgt9Zjh4Y)*

How to use: "Learning a language requires daily practice. Similarly, developing any skill needs consistent effort."

Why it works: Shows ability to make connections between different ideas.

6. "Personally..."

Purpose: Expressing your individual opinion or preference

> *Real IELTS Example: "Personally, I don't think someone should be forced but as individuals, we should be aware..."*

How to use: "Personally, I think children should learn to cook at a young age." / "Personally, I prefer reading..."

Why it works: Signals personal opinion clearly, which examiners look for.

7. "Obviously..."

Purpose: Stating something clear or logical (use sparingly)

> *Real IELTS Example: "Dogs for obvious reasons-you can keep them as pets."*

How to use: "Obviously, parents want the best education..." / "Obviously, regular exercise is important..."

Why it works: Shows logical thinking (avoid overusing or sounding condescending).

8. "Actually..."

Purpose: Correcting, adding surprising info, or emphasizing

> *Real IELTS Example: "Actually, recently I did receive flowers and I can't talk enough about flowers."*

How to use: "I thought I'd hate living abroad, but actually, I love it."

Why it works: Natural discourse marker adding emphasis and authentic flow.

9. "In fact..."

Purpose: Adding supporting information or emphasizing truth

> *Real IELTS Example: "In fact, even when I'm going on a walk or a run I always have the map on my hand..."*

How to use: "I enjoy cooking. In fact, I spend about two hours every Sunday preparing meals..."

Why it works: Adds weight to arguments by providing supporting evidence.

10. "Basically..."

Purpose: Summarizing or simplifying a complex idea

> *Real IELTS Example: "Basically, just the look of excitement on her face... effectively cut her loan by half."*

How to use: "The course covers many topics, but basically, it's about understanding human behavior."

Why it works: Distills complex information into clear, simple terms.

11. "Generally..."

Purpose: Making broad statements / talking about usual situations

> *Real IELTS Example: "Generally speaking, I love Netflix-you have all the options you want."*

How to use: "Generally, I prefer warm weather..." / "Generally speaking, people are family-oriented."

Why it works: Expresses generalizations while allowing room for exceptions.

12. "Specifically..."

Purpose: Being precise or giving exact details

> *Real IELTS Example: "The mountains specifically-I always handpick locations which have mountains."*

How to use: "I love music, specifically jazz..." / "The program focuses on business, specifically marketing."

Why it works: Demonstrates precision and detail in preferences.

13. "Particularly..."

Purpose: Emphasizing something special or noteworthy

> *Real IELTS Example: "It's particularly true when you get to watch it as soon as it comes out."*

How to use: "I enjoy all sports, particularly swimming and tennis."

Why it works: Sophisticated vocabulary choice over simpler words like 'especially'.

14. "Definitely..."

Purpose: Expressing strong agreement or certainty

> *Real IELTS Example: "Definitely, it's one of my favorite things to do. I actually love nature."*

How to use: "Would I recommend this course? Definitely. It changed my perspective completely."

Why it works: Shows strong conviction and confidence in opinions.

15. "Absolutely..."

Purpose: Expressing complete agreement or strong emphasis

> *Real IELTS Example: "Absolutely. I think there's lots of repressed emotions and stress..."*

How to use: "Do you think education should be free? Absolutely. Everyone deserves equal opportunities."

Why it works: Stronger than 'definitely'—shows absolute certainty.

16. "Ultimately..."

Purpose: Introducing final conclusion or most important point

> *Real IELTS Example: "Ultimately, I realized that all this became really useful for me to gain all the skills..."*

How to use: "There are pros and cons. Ultimately, I think the decision depends on circumstances."

Why it works: Ideal for Part 3 discussions requiring considered conclusions.

BEST PRACTICES & STRATEGY GUIDE

Tips for Natural Usage

- **Don't force it:** Use these phrases only when they naturally fit your intended meaning.
- **Practice in context:** Try using them in practice responses, not in isolation.
- **Listen for rhythm:** Native speakers use these phrases with natural intonation.
- **Vary your choices:** Don't use the same phrases repeatedly in one response.
- **Focus on meaning:** The phrase should help express your idea, not complicate it.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Overusing academic phrases:** Sounding too formal can be unnatural for Speaking.
- **Mixing registers:** Don't combine very informal and very formal language together.
- **Ignoring context:** Some phrases work better in Part 3 than Part 1.
- **Memorizing chunks:** Phrases should sound natural, not rehearsed.
- **Forgetting intonation:** Practice how these phrases sound, not just how they look.

IELTS VOCABULARY IMPROVEMENT PLAN

Master the art of expanding your English vocabulary through a proven 3-step system designed specifically for IELTS success to transform how you learn, retain, and use new words effectively.

01. Read and Listen

Immerse yourself in authentic English content from sources you genuinely enjoy and find interesting. Studies show reading/listening to genuine sources is the #1 way to improve.

02. Record

You must record any new words you hear or read. Use a notebook or phone apps so that you remember them effectively.

03. Review

It is essential that you regularly review these new words and phrases in order to retain them in your memory long-term.

Reading: Foundation for Success

- **Spot new words:** Underline or write them down.
- **Guess meaning:** Attempt to guess meanings before checking dictionaries.
- **Use free resources:** Use blogs, news sites, and eBooks.
- **Read daily:** Integrate English reading into daily routines.

Listening: Expand on the Go

- **Listen to what you love:** Football, fashion, science, podcasts. Write down new phrases.
- **Use free platforms:** YouTube and podcasts offer unlimited material.
- **Listen while commuting:** Put earbuds in while walking, traveling, or working out.

Capture Your Learning

1. **Buy a notebook:** Simple notebook to record new phrases.
2. **Use your phone:** Use apps like Memrise to record lists.
3. **Add memory aids:** Include collocations, synonyms, antonyms, pronunciation, example sentences, and pictures.

Review: The Key to Retention

- **Do it regularly:** Review 1 week, 2 weeks, and 1 month after learning (5-10 mins/day is better than cramming).
- **Make it fun:** Word games on Memrise/Quizlet or create stories.
- **Use them:** Apply words in speaking and writing practice answers.

FREE ONLINE RESOURCES & LEARNING TOOLS

You do not need to spend any money to improve your vocabulary. All essential resources are freely available on the internet.

Category	Resource	Description & Use Case
News & Current Affairs	BBC News	Covers common IELTS topics daily via audio and articles.
	The Guardian	Great selection of news articles and podcasts for advanced vocabulary.
Podcasts & Audio	Stitcher	Access to hundreds of thousands of podcasts across all interests.
	YouTube	Endless supply of videos; search for topics you genuinely enjoy.
	TED Talks	Fun, inspiring talks by leading global thinkers with clear transcripts.
Interactive Tools & Reading	Quizlet	Simple flashcard and quiz tools for learning anything.
	Memrise	App for recording, organizing, and reviewing vocabulary funly.
	eBooks	Hundreds of thousands of free books available online.

Key Takeaway: The resources are free, the method is proven, and the results are in your hands. Start today with just one article, one podcast, or one video about something you love. Your vocabulary journey begins with a single word.
Contact/Support: chris@ieltsadvantage.com

Ready to Take Your IELTS Speaking to the Next Level?

While this guide gives you the vocabulary foundation, achieving Band 7-9 requires comprehensive preparation, expert feedback, and proven strategies.

- Complete step-by-step preparation for all four IELTS skills
- Personal feedback from expert IELTS teachers
- Proven strategies that have helped more students achieve Band 7, 8, and 9
- Live lessons, recorded masterclasses, and mock tests with detailed scoring

Join the IELTS Advantage VIP Course: ieltsadvantage.com/vip-academy